# GE1218: SOCIAL ENTREPRENEURSHIP AND INNOVATION

**Effective Term**
Semester A 2025/26

## Part I Course Overview

**Course Title**
Social Entrepreneurship and Innovation

**Subject Code**
GE - Gateway Education
**Course Number**
1218

**Academic Unit**
Public and International Affairs (PIA)

**College/School**
College of Liberal Arts and Social Sciences (CH)

**Course Duration**
One Semester

**Credit Units**
3

**Level**
B1, B2, B3, B4 - Bachelor's Degree

**GE Area (Primary)**
Area 2 - Study of Societies, Social and Business Organisations

**Medium of Instruction**
English

**Medium of Assessment**
English

**Prerequisites**
Nil

**Precursors**
Nil

**Equivalent Courses**
Nil

**Exclusive Courses**
Nil

**Additional Information**

Nil

# Part II Course Details

**Abstract**

Global and local grand challenges (e.g., inequality, climate change, inadequate housing, discrimination) and the acceleration of change in the economy and social ecosystem require citizens today to take an active part in driving positive change. This phenomenon becomes known as 'social entrepreneurship', a rapidly growing trend where private individuals and groups mobilize private resources and using market mechanisms to benefit the public. Rather than leaving societal problems to the government or businesses, social entrepreneurs lead as change agents and take up the responsibility to drive for a better world and become valuable partners of the government and non-profits in experimenting with new solutions.

The local and global interest in 'social entrepreneurship', 'social innovation', and 'social enterprise' has grown rapidly in the past two decades. Social entrepreneurship is a type of entrepreneurship that relies on economic activities that aim to create social outcomes. Social innovation refers to the pursuit of innovation where the benefits accrue to the society than a particular individual or organization. Social enterprise is the business entity to implement social entrepreneurship and innovation. Social enterprise is a form of business but, unlike conventional commercial businesses, it focuses on bringing about solutions to social problems in a financially sustainable (and often innovative) manner. Examples include 'work integration social enterprises' (WISEs) that employ stigmatized groups (e.g., ex-criminals, people with disability, homeless, refugees, ethnic minority) and socially innovative ventures (e.g., new types of transitional housing, taxis that cater to the elderly, etc). New developments in this area include Certified B Corporation, platform cooperatives, to the use of blockchain and AI to assist poor farmers; many of whom also employ social enterprise models.

This course aims to educate students as positive agents of development and responsible citizens by equipping them with the theories, concepts, and tools to be social entrepreneurs. The skills learned in this course is equally applicable to conventional (for-profit) entrepreneurship. The course integrates Western and non-Western theories, practices, and cases to social entrepreneurship, and thus offers a unique design in the world. It also incorporates and integrates the use of generative artificial intelligence (AI) as part of the learning process on aspects that are relevant to social entrepreneurship. As social entrepreneurship is multidimensional, this course adopts a multi-disciplinary approach by combining humanities, public sector management, business management, design, information and communication technology, and technology management.

**Course Intended Learning Outcomes (CILOs)**

| | CILOs | Weighting (if app.) | DEC-A1 | DEC-A2 | DEC-A3 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Identify the differences between commercial enterprise and social enterprise, the meaning of social entrepreneurship and innovation, the key features and different types of social enterprises and social entrepreneurship opportunities in Hong Kong and internationally. | 10 | x | x | x |
| 2 | Discover why and what innovative solutions have been created by social entrepreneurs and innovators both at home and abroad to solve societal problems. | 20 | | x | x |
| 3 | Explore how social entrepreneurs and innovators draw on business models and market-based mechanisms to create positive and innovative change. | 20 | | x | x |
| 4 | Analyse some of the best practices in social entrepreneurship, strategies and social innovation strategies, successes and failures, opportunities and pitfalls in the field of social entrepreneurship and innovation. | 20 | | x | x |

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|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 5 | Develop effective communication skills and multimedia skills, including generative AI skills, to bring about positive change and societal improvements by generating and analyzing new ideas and solutions, narrating the issues and challenges, conducting analysis and exploring new perspectives of social entrepreneurs. | 20 | x | | |
| 6 | Relate the spirit of social entrepreneurship to community building and develop a sense of civic responsibility. | 10 | x | | |

A1: Attitude
Develop an attitude of discovery/innovation/creativity, as demonstrated by students possessing a strong sense of curiosity, asking questions actively, challenging assumptions or engaging in inquiry together with teachers.

A2: Ability
Develop the ability/skill needed to discover/innovate/create, as demonstrated by students possessing critical thinking skills to assess ideas, acquiring research skills, synthesizing knowledge across disciplines or applying academic knowledge to real-life problems.

A3: Accomplishments
Demonstrate accomplishment of discovery/innovation/creativity through producing /constructing creative works/new artefacts, effective solutions to real-life problems or new processes.

**Learning and Teaching Activities (LTAs)**

| | LTAs | Brief Description | CILO No. | Hours/week (if applicable) |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Lectures | Lay out the main ideas of social entrepreneurship and enterprise and their key concepts, characteristic features; how they are related to social innovation; different types of social enterprises; opportunities and constraints faced by social entrepreneurs in Hong Kong and other parts of the globe. | 1, 2, 3, 4, 5 | |
| 2 | Readings | Facilitate students to have in-depth understanding of the key concepts, ideas, models, and practices of social entrepreneurship and enterprise in the local and international settings. | 1, 2, 3, 4, 5 | |

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|---|---|---|---|---|
| 3 | Guest Lectures by Practitioners | Provide real life examples of best practices, business strategies and resources management, successes and failures in the field of social entrepreneurship and enterprise. | 2, 3, 4 | |
| 4 | Case Studies & Class Exercise and Discussions | Equip students with insightful cases, successful and less sucessful, and class exercise and discussions to understand, explain and communicate the challenges and best practices of social entrepreneurship and enterprise at home and abroad. | 2, 3, 4, 5, 6 | |
| 5 | Site Visit | Enable students to experience the spirit of social entrepreneurship by seeing and visiting real life practices of social enterprises in town. | 2, 3, 4, 6 | |

**Assessment Tasks / Activities (ATs)**

| | ATs | CILO No. | Weighting (%) | Remarks ("-" for nil entry) | Allow Use of GenAI? |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Class Participation: Student’ s class participation includes actively participation in class activities and exercises, class discussions, asking useful questions, and volunteering in class activities. | 1, 2, 3, 4, 5 | 10 | - | Yes |

| | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 2 | Social Enterprise Ideation Challenge: Each student will generate ideas and solutions to tackle a chosen social environmental problem. This requires students to think deeply and creatively about the social problem of interest and creatively write and frame the social problems, the mission of the social enterprise, and the potential ideas or solutions to tackle the problem. Students will generate the ideas and solutions using a "manual approach" (relying on their mind and hand), compare it with an "AI approach", and a "human-AI combined approach". This three-thronged approach builds the bilities in identifying accurate information and understand the subtleties, complexities, and intricacies of social entrepreneurship.<br><br>As part of the learning process, students are required to identify the strengths and weaknesses of AI only approach, human only approach, and the combined AI-human approach. | 2, 3, 6 | 25 | This is an individual work. To be submitted near the middle of the semester.<br><br>A combination of AI (e.g., ChatGPT or other AI tools including text-to-image AI) and human problem solving is required in this assignment. Students must acknowledge their use of AI in responsible manner by including the original prompts and the outputs. | Yes |

| | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 3 | Social Business Plan Presentation: Students will conduct an in-depth investigation of a chosen societal problem and design social business plan to address the problem. This requires students to conduct problem analysis, market analysis, opportunity analysis, and solution feasibility using a "social business plan canvass".<br><br>Students will use a "AI and human collaborative approach" to facilitate various activities in the social business plan that include idea generation, problem identification, market-opportunity analysis, financial analysis, to impact analysis.<br><br>Students will present and defend their social business plan to the teacher and whenever feasible, in front of expert judges. Teachers will make oral assessment in class during the poster pitching. | 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6 | 40 | This is a group work, with the group size to be determined by the course leader depending on the class size. To be submitted near the end of the semester.<br><br>A combination of AI (e.g., ChatGPT or other AI tools including text-to-image AI) and human problem solving is required in this assignment.<br><br>Students must acknowledge their use of AI in responsible manner by including the original prompts and the outputs. | Yes |

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|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 4 | Final Quiz: Students will take a final quiz, that will examine what they have learned, solving cases, applying knowledge into a problem, etc. | 1, 2, 3, 4, 5 | 25 | This is an individual work and to be administered in near the end or the last class of the course. | No |

**Continuous Assessment (%)**

100

**Examination (%)**

0

**Assessment Rubrics (AR)**

**Assessment Task**

1. Class Participation

**Criterion**

This assesses active participation throughout the semester. It includes participating actively in class activities, class exercises, class discussion or debate, asking clarifications, volunteering in the class; avoid creating troubles that could hamper other students' learning experience or the smooth operations of the course.

**Excellent (A+, A, A-)**

Demonstrating very positive and proactive attitudes in class discussions; showing superior preparation of the readings before coming to class; and very active interaction in class with unique ideas and insightful questions

**Good (B+, B, B-)**

Demonstrating good & positive attitudes in class discussions; showing good preparation of the readings before coming to class; and active interaction in class with some stimulating ideas and insightful questions.

**Fair (C+, C, C-)**

Demonstrating good attitudes in class discussions; showing adequate preparation of the readings before coming to class; and some interaction in class but no stimulating ideas and little insightful questions.

**Marginal (D)**

Demonstrating non-positive attitudes class discussions; showing inadequate preparation of the readings before coming to class; and little interaction in class with no stimulating ideas or insightful questions.

**Failure (F)**

Demonstrating negative attitude in class discussions; showing poor preparation of the readings before coming to class; and no interaction in class at all.

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**Assessment Task**

Social Enterprise Ideation Challenge

**Criterion**

This assesses students' logical and creative thinking about a social problem of interest and creatively write and frame the social problems, articulate the mission of the social enterprise, and express the potential ideas or solutions to tackle the problem. Students will be assessed based on how well they can demonstrate the use of "manual approach" (relying on their mind and hand), compare it with an "AI approach", and a "human-AI combined approach" in terms of

identifying accurate information, in being creative and innovative, and understand the complexities and intricacies of social entrepreneurship.

**Excellent (A+, A, A-)**

Demonstrating outstanding ideas and outstanding innovative results to make a difference in real-life issues and problem; outstanding creativity in communicating ideas and solutions in writing; strong evidence that the suggested ideas and solutions would or have created societal value; and impressive learning benefits in using AI in this process.

**Good (B+, B, B-)**

Demonstrating good ideas and innovative results to make a difference in real-life issues and problems; good creativity in communicating the ideas and solutions in writing; good evidence that the suggested ideas and solutions would or have created societal value; and good learning benefits in using AI in this process.

**Fair (C+, C, C-)**

Demonstrating some fair ideas and somewhat innovative results to make a difference in real-life issues and problems; fair creativity in communicating the ideas and solutions in writing; fair evidence that the suggested ideas and solutions would or have created societal value; and fair learning benefits in using AI in this process.

**Marginal (D)**

Demonstrating weak ideas and somewhat weak innovative results to make a difference in real-life issues and problems; weak creativity in communicating the ideas and solutions in writing; weak evidence that the suggested ideas and solutions would or have created societal value; and weak learning benefits in using AI in this process.

**Failure (F)**

Demonstrating inadequate ideas and clear lack of innovative results to make a difference in real-life issues and problems; very weak creativity in communicating the ideas and solutions in writing; very weak evidence that the suggested ideas and solutions would or have created societal value; and very limited learning benefits in using AI in this process.

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**Assessment Task**

3. Social Business Plan Presentation

**Criterion**

This assesses students, in groups, ability to conduct problem analysis, market analysis, opportunity analysis, financial analysis, and impact analysis and solution feasibility using a “social business plan canvass”, and their ability in using a “AI and human collaborative approach” and in pitching the social business plan.

**Excellent (A+, A, A-)**

Demonstration of outstanding ability in doing in-depth investigation independently and systematically to tackle a societal problem of interest ; creative and stimulating application of materials to establish a very convincing solution for the problem; highly effective in communicating the ideas and defending the group’s position; strong evidence of superior critical analysis and synthesis; and excellent ability in using a “AI and human collaborative approach” and in pitching the social business plan.

**Good (B+, B, B-)**

Demonstration of good ability in doing in-depth investigation independently and systematically to tackle a societal problem of interest; good level of creativity and stimulating application of materials to establish a convincing solution for the problem; effective in communicating the ideas and defending the group’s position; good evidence of superior critical analysis and synthesis; and excellent ability in using a “AI and human collaborative approach” and in pitching the social business plan.

**Fair (C+, C, C-)**

Demonstration of adequate ability in doing in-depth investigation independently and systematically to tackle a societal problem of interest; adequate level of creativity and stimulating application of materials to establish a somewhat convincing solution for the problem; fairly effective in communicating the ideas and defending the group’s position; fair evidence of

superior critical analysis and synthesis; and fair ability in using a “AI and human collaborative approach” and in pitching the social business plan.

**Marginal (D)**

Demonstration of limited ability in doing in-depth investigation independently and systematically to tackle a societal problem of interest; limited level of creativity and stimulating application of materials to establish a convincing solution for the problem; limited effectiveness in communicating the ideas and defending the group’s position; limited evidence of superior critical analysis and synthesis; and limited ability in using a “AI and human collaborative approach” and in pitching the social business plan.

**Failure (F)**

Demonstration of poor ability in doing in-depth investigation independently and systematically to tackle a societal problem of interest; poor level of creativity and stimulating application of materials to establish a convincing solution for the problem; poor effectiveness in communicating the ideas and defending the group’s position; poor evidence of superior critical analysis and synthesis; and poor ability in using a “AI and human collaborative approach” and in pitching the social business plan.

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**Assessment Task**

4. Final Quiz

**Criterion**

Students will take a final quiz near or at the end of the semester. This will tests what they have learned, and solving cases, that tests how they apply the knowledge into a real life situation.

**Excellent (A+, A, A-)**

Outstanding performance in the quiz; evidence of extensive knowledge base in the subject matter; demonstration of excellent, critical and analytical thinking, rigorous analysis of materials and evaluation of issues.

**Good (B+, B, B-)**

Good performance in the quiz; evidence of good knowledge base in the subject matter; demonstration of good analytical thinking, good analysis of materials and evaluation of issues.

**Fair (C+, C, C-)**

Fair performance in the quiz, evidence of adequate knowledge base in the subject matter; demonstration of some critical and analytical thinking, fairly adequate analysis of materials and evaluation of issues.

**Marginal (D)**

Weak performance in the quiz, evidence of weak knowledge base in the subject matter; limited critical and analytical thinking, insufficient analysis of materials and evaluation of issues.

**Failure (F)**

Poor performance in the quiz, evidence of some knowledge base in the subject matter; poor critical and analytical thinking, poor analysis of materials and evaluation of issues.

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# Part III Other Information

**Keyword Syllabus**

Social entrepreneurship; social innovation; social enterprise; tackling grand challenges; solving societal problems; United Nations Sustainable Development Goals; concepts of social entrepreneurship and social innovation; motives for social entrepreneurship; promises of social business; social problems as business opportunities; partnership between the state, business and civil society; business strategies and sustainability; qualities and traits of social entrepreneurs; doing well

by doing good; pitching ideas; communicating new ideas; social enterprise ideation challenge; use of AI and human collaboration approach.

**Reading List**

**Compulsory Readings**

| | Title |
|---|---|
| 1 | Bornstein, David (2004) How to Change the World: Social Entrepreneurs and the Power of New Ideas, Oxford: OUP. |
| 2 | Mair, J., & Rathert, N. (2021). Alternative organizing with social purpose: Revisiting institutional analysis of market-based activity. Socio-Economic Review, 19(2), 817-836. |
| 3 | Chandra, Y., & Wong, L. 2016. Social Entrepreneurship in the Greater China: Policy and Cases. Routledge (in print). |
| 4 | Nicholls, Alex ed. (2006) Social Entrepreneurship: New Models of Sustainable Social Change, Oxford University Press. |
| 5 | Yunus, M., Moingeon, B., & Lehmann-Ortega, L. 2010. Building Social Business Models: Lessons from the Grameen Experience. Long Range Planning, 43: 308-325. |
| 6 | Ashoka: Innovators for the Public: profiles of Ashoka Fellows: https://www.ashoka.org/ |
| 7 | Skoll Foundation (Skoll entrepreneurs). http://www.skollfoundation.org/skoll-entrepreneurs/ |
| 8 | Schwab Foundation for Social Entrepreneurship. http://www.schwabfound.org/sf/index.htm |
| 9 | Kiva: a platform to match social investors and the needy. http://www.kiva.org/ |
| 10 | Social Enterprise UK: a platform of social enterprises in UK: http://www.socialenterprise.org.uk/ |
| 11 | Community Interest Company (CIC): UK’s legal pathway to social enterprise: https://www.gov.uk/government/organisations/office-of-the-regulator-of-community-interest-companies |
| 12 | BCorporation: a certification of business for good: https://www.bcorporation.net/en-us/ |
| 13 | Social Enterprise Summit (Hong Kong). http://www.social-enterprise.org.hk/ |
| 14 | Directory of Social Enterprise in Hong Kong: https://socialenterprise.org.hk/en/sedb |
| 15 | Social Enterprise Endorsement Mark (Hong Kong): https://sechamber.hk/en_gb/home/ |

**Additional Readings**

| | Title |
|---|---|
| 1 | Nil |

# Annex (for GE courses only)

**A. Please specify the Gateway Education Programme Intended Learning Outcomes (PILOs) that the course is aligned to and relate them to the CILOs stated in Part II, Section 2 of this form:**

Please indicate which CILO(s) is/are related to this PILO, if any (can be more than one CILOs in each PILO)

**PILO 1: Demonstrate the capacity for self-directed learning**

2, 3, 4

**PILO 2: Explain the basic methodologies and techniques of inquiry of the arts and humanities, social sciences, business, and science and technology**

1, 2, 3, 4, 5

**PILO 3: Demonstrate critical thinking skills**

2, 3, 4, 5

**PILO 4: Interpret information and numerical data**

2, 3, 4

**PILO 5: Produce structured, well-organised and fluent text**

2, 3, 4, 5

**PILO 6: Demonstrate effective oral communication skills**

2, 3, 4, 5

**PILO 7: Demonstrate an ability to work effectively in a team**

2, 3, 4, 5

**PILO 8: Recognise important characteristics of their own culture(s) and at least one other culture, and their impact on global issues**

2, 3, 4, 5

**PILO 9: Value ethical and socially responsible actions**

4, 5, 6

**PILO 10: Demonstrate the attitude and/or ability to accomplish discovery and/or innovation**

2, 3, 4, 6

**B. Please select an assessment task for collecting evidence of student achievement for quality assurance purposes. Please retain at least one sample of student achievement across a period of three years.**

**Selected Assessment Task**

Students -- in groups -- conduct a poster pitching of a social entrepreneurship solution to tackle a societal problems. The poster will be collected for quality assurance audit.